Catechism.

APPENDIX II

The Books of the Bible

Author, date, setting, theme, and a literary outline for each of the 66 books

Each entry gives a traditional, widely held starting point. Where scholars disagree about authorship or date, the entry says so briefly and does not try to settle the question. Dates are approximate. The outline follows the structure of the book itself and is not tied to the reading plan.

Contents

1 **Law: The Pentateuch**
Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy

2 **Old Testament: History**
Joshua, Judges, Ruth, 1 Samuel, 2 Samuel, 1 Kings, 2 Kings, 1 Chronicles, 2 Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther

3 **Old Testament: Wisdom and Poetry**
Job, Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs

4 **Old Testament: The Major Prophets**
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5 **Old Testament: The Minor Prophets**
Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi

6 **New Testament: Gospels and Acts**
Matthew, Mark, Luke, John, Acts

7 **New Testament: Paul's Letters**
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8 **New Testament: General Letters and Revelation**
Hebrews, James, 1 Peter, 2 Peter, 1 John, 2 John, 3 John, Jude, Revelation

Law: The Pentateuch

Genesis

The book of beginnings

AUTHOR	Traditionally Moses.
DATE	Traditionally linked to the time of Moses, about 1400 to 1200 BC. The events span from creation to about 1800 BC.
SETTING	Written for Israel before entering the promised land. It tells where the world, sin, and the chosen family came from.
GENRE	Narrative, with genealogies and poetry.
THEME	God creates a good world, sin breaks it, and God begins a plan to bless all nations through Abraham's family.
KEY VERSE	Genesis 12:2-3
IN THIS PLAN	Units 1-3; Days 1-59 (32 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Genesis plants the promise of an offspring who will crush the serpent (3:15) and bless all nations through Abraham's line (12:3). Judah's line carries the scepter (49:10), and Isaac, Joseph, and the ram caught in the thicket all look ahead to the sacrifice and rescue God would provide.

HOW TO READ IT

Read Genesis as the foundation for everything after it. Watch for repeated patterns: a promise, a threat to the promise, and God's faithful rescue. The genealogies are not filler. They trace the line of promise from Adam through Abraham to the twelve tribes.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:3	Creation in six days and the Sabbath
2:4-4:26	Eden, the fall, and the first family
5:1-6:8	From Adam to Noah
6:9-9:29	Noah and the flood
10:1-11:26	The nations and Babel
11:27-25:18	Abraham
25:19-28:9	Isaac, Jacob, and Esau
28:10-36:43	Jacob
37:1-50:26	Joseph and the family in Egypt

Exodus

God rescues and dwells with his people

AUTHOR	Traditionally Moses.
DATE	Traditionally dated to the time of Moses. Scholars differ on the date of the exodus itself, often placed in the 1400s or 1200s BC.
SETTING	Israel in Egyptian slavery, then in the wilderness at Mount Sinai.
GENRE	Narrative and law.
THEME	God redeems Israel from slavery, makes a covenant with them at Sinai, and comes to live among them in the tabernacle.
KEY VERSE	Exodus 19:4-6
IN THIS PLAN	Units 5-6; Days 94-128 (22 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Moses the deliverer, the Passover lamb, the manna, the water from the rock, the tabernacle, and the priesthood all point to Jesus. John 1:14 says the Word "tabernacled" among us, and Paul calls Christ our Passover lamb (1 Corinthians 5:7).

HOW TO READ IT

Exodus has two halves: redemption (chapters 1-18) and covenant and worship (chapters 19-40). Notice that God rescues Israel before he gives the law. Obedience in this book always follows grace.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:25	Israel in Egypt and the birth of Moses
3:1-7:7	The call of Moses
7:8-11:10	The plagues
12:1-13:16	The Passover and the exodus
13:17-15:21	The crossing of the sea
15:22-18:27	From the sea to Sinai
19:1-24:18	The covenant at Sinai
25:1-31:18	Instructions for the tabernacle
32:1-34:35	The golden calf and the renewal of the covenant
35:1-40:38	Building the tabernacle

Leviticus

How a holy God lives among a sinful people

AUTHOR	Traditionally Moses.
DATE	Traditionally set at Mount Sinai in the time of Moses.
SETTING	Israel camped at Sinai, with the tabernacle newly built.
GENRE	Law, especially priestly and ritual instruction.
THEME	God is holy, sin is serious, and sacrifice and priesthood provide a way to approach him.
KEY VERSE	Leviticus 19:2
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 6; Days 129-143 (12 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Jesus is the sacrifice, the priest, and the tabernacle at once. The book of Hebrews explains that the offerings, the priesthood, and the Day of Atonement are shadows of what Christ accomplished once for all.

HOW TO READ IT

Do not read Leviticus as a list of random rules. Its question is how a holy God can live among sinners. Look for the repeated words “holy,” “clean,” “atonement,” and “forgiven.”

OUTLINE

1:1-7:38	The offerings
1:1-17	The burnt offering
8:1-10:20	The priesthood begins
8:1-36	The ordination of Aaron and his sons
9:1-24	The first sacrifices and the glory of the LORD
11:1-15:33	Clean and unclean
11:1-47	Clean and unclean animals
12:1-8	Childbirth
16:1-34	The Day of Atonement
16:1-10	Preparation and the two goats
16:11-28	The blood and the scapegoat
17:1-27:34	The call to holy living
17:1-16	The sanctity of blood
18:1-20:27	Sexual ethics, love of neighbor, and penalties

Numbers

A generation in the wilderness

AUTHOR	Traditionally Moses.
DATE	Traditionally covers about forty years after the exodus.
SETTING	Israel counted and organized at Sinai, then wandering until a new generation is ready to enter the land.
GENRE	Narrative, law, and census lists.
THEME	God stays faithful even when his people rebel, and he leads a new generation toward the promise.
KEY VERSE	Numbers 14:18
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 7; Days 150-173 (16 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The bronze serpent lifted up in the wilderness is a picture of Christ on the cross (John 3:14-15). The rock that gave water, the manna, and the cities of refuge all point forward, and Balaam's oracle speaks of a star and a scepter out of Israel (24:17).

HOW TO READ IT

Numbers alternates between narrative and lists. The census lists show God's careful care for his people. The stories show their repeated unbelief. Pay attention to how Moses intercedes and how God keeps his promise anyway.

OUTLINE

1:1-10:10	Preparing at Sinai
10:11-12:16	From Sinai to Paran
13:1-14:45	The twelve spies and the refusal to enter
15:1-19:22	Years of wandering
20:1-22:1	Toward Moab
22:2-25:18	Balaam and Baal of Peor
22:2-24:25	Balaam's oracles
26:1-36:13	A new generation
26:1-65	The second census

Deuteronomy

Moses' farewell sermons

AUTHOR	Traditionally Moses, with an account of his death added.
DATE	Traditionally set just before Israel enters the land, about 1400 to 1200 BC.
SETTING	Israel on the plains of Moab, with the Jordan ahead of them.
GENRE	Sermon and covenant renewal.
THEME	Love the Lord with all your heart, obey him, and remember what he has done.
KEY VERSE	Deuteronomy 6:4-5
IN THIS PLAN	Units 7 and 15; Days 174-599 (16 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Moses promises a prophet like himself (18:15), and the New Testament identifies him as Jesus. Jesus answered every temptation in the wilderness with words from this book, and Paul says Christ became a curse for us (Galatians 3:13, quoting Deuteronomy 21:23).

HOW TO READ IT

Deuteronomy is a sermon, not a law code. Notice the repeated words "remember," "hear," "today," and "love." The book's pattern follows ancient covenant documents: history, commands, blessings and curses, and witnesses.

OUTLINE

1:1-4:43	First address: look back
1:1-46	From Horeb to Kadesh
4:44-11:32	Second address: the call to love and obey
4:44-5:33	The Ten Commandments restated
12:1-26:19	The law applied
12:1-32	One place of worship
27:1-30:20	Covenant renewal
27:1-26	Ebal and Gerizim, and the curses
31:1-34:12	Moses' last days
31:1-30	Joshua commissioned
32:1-52	The Song of Moses

Old Testament: History

Joshua

Entering the promised land

AUTHOR Not named in the text. Tradition connects it with Joshua, with possible later editing.

DATE Events are often placed in the late 1400s or 1200s BC.

SETTING Israel under Joshua crosses the Jordan and takes possession of the land.

GENRE Historical narrative.

THEME God keeps his promise and gives Israel the land, and calls them to remain faithful.

KEY VERSE Joshua 21:45

IN THIS PLAN Unit 8; Days 200-214 (9 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Joshua's name is the same as Jesus in Hebrew. He leads God's people into the rest of the promised land, while Hebrews 4 teaches that Jesus leads his people into a greater rest. The commander of the LORD's army (5:13-15) is often seen as a preview of Christ.

HOW TO READ IT

Notice that the book stresses both God's gift of the land and the people's duty to obey. Read the conquest accounts alongside the repeated reminders that God was giving the land and judging the nations for their sin.

OUTLINE

1:1-5:12	Preparing and crossing the Jordan
1:1-18	Joshua commissioned
2:1-24	Rahab and the spies
5:13-12:24	The conquest
5:13-6:27	The commander of the LORD's army and Jericho
7:1-8:35	Achan's sin, Ai, and the renewal at Ebal
13:1-21:45	Dividing the land
13:1-33	Land east of the Jordan
14:1-15:63	Caleb and Judah
22:1-24:33	Final charges
22:1-34	The altar by the Jordan
23:1-16	Joshua's farewell

Judges

A cycle of sin, rescue, and decline

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. Jewish tradition names Samuel.
DATE	Covers the period between Joshua and the monarchy, roughly 1200 to 1050 BC.
SETTING	Israel in the land without a king, surrounded by other peoples.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	Israel repeatedly turns from God, and God repeatedly raises up deliverers, yet the people grow worse and a king is needed.
KEY VERSE	Judges 21:25
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 8; Days 215-229 (9 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Each judge is a flawed rescuer, and the book keeps asking for a king who will be better. The true Judge and Deliverer is Jesus, who rescues once for all and reigns forever.

HOW TO READ IT

Read the book as a downward spiral: sin, oppression, cry for help, deliverance, and then relapse. The refrain "In those days there was no king in Israel" signals what the book is asking.

OUTLINE

1:1-3:6	Why the land was not fully taken
1:1-36	Incomplete conquest
2:1-5	The angel at Bochim
2:6-3:6	The cycle introduced
3:7-16:31	The judges
3:7-11	Othniel
3:12-30	Ehud
3:31	Shamgar
4:1-5:31	Deborah, Barak, and Jael
17:1-21:25	Israel's moral collapse
17:1-18:31	Micah's idol and the tribe of Dan
19:1-30	The Levite and his concubine
20:1-21:25	Civil war against Benjamin

Ruth

Faithful love in dark times

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. Tradition has said Samuel.
DATE	Set in the time of the judges. Written probably after David's rise.
SETTING	A family from Bethlehem moves to Moab and returns.
GENRE	Short narrative.
THEME	God provides a redeemer for Naomi and Ruth, and through them prepares the way for David.
KEY VERSE	Ruth 4:14
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 8; Days 230-232 (2 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Boaz is a picture of the kinsman redeemer, one who buys back what was lost. Ruth, a foreigner, becomes the great-grandmother of David and appears in the family line of Jesus (Matthew 1:5).

HOW TO READ IT

Ruth is a short story with careful structure. Watch for the words "redeem," "kindness," and "refuge." Notice how ordinary acts of faithfulness carry God's larger plan.

OUTLINE

1:1-22	Loss in Moab and return to Bethlehem
1:1-5	Famine, exile, and three deaths
1:6-18	Ruth's pledge to Naomi
2:1-23	Ruth gleans in Boaz's field
2:1-7	Ruth meets Boaz
2:8-17	Boaz's kindness
3:1-18	Ruth at the threshing floor
3:1-5	Naomi's plan
3:6-15	Ruth and Boaz at midnight
4:1-22	Boaz redeems
4:1-12	The nearer kinsman and the gate
4:13-17	Marriage and the birth of Obed

1 Samuel

From judges to kings

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. Often thought to rely on earlier records.
DATE	Covers about 1100 to 1010 BC. Final form is often dated after the kingdom divided.
SETTING	Israel moves from tribal rule under Eli and Samuel to the monarchy under Saul, with David rising.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	God gives Israel a king, rejects Saul for disobedience, and chooses David.
KEY VERSE	1 Samuel 16:7
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 9; Days 235-261 (11 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

David, the anointed shepherd king from Bethlehem, anticipates the greater Son of David. Hannah's song (2:1-10) speaks of God's "anointed" and foreshadows Mary's song in Luke 1.

HOW TO READ IT

The book turns on a contrast between outward and inward: Saul looks like a king, while David is a man after God's heart. Pay attention to who is listening to God and who is not.

OUTLINE

1:1-7:17	Eli and Samuel
1:1-2:11	Hannah's prayer and Samuel's birth
8:1-12:25	Israel asks for a king
8:1-22	The elders demand a king
9:1-10:27	Saul anointed
13:1-15:35	Saul's failures
13:1-22	The unlawful sacrifice
14:1-52	Jonathan's victory and Saul's rash oath
16:1-20:42	David's rise
16:1-23	David anointed and brought to Saul
17:1-58	David and Goliath
21:1-31:13	David on the run
21:1-22:23	Nob and the cave of Adullam
23:1-26:25	Saul pursues, and David spares him

2 Samuel

The reign of David

AUTHOR	Not named in the text.
DATE	Covers David's reign, about 1010 to 970 BC.
SETTING	David becomes king over Judah, then over all Israel, based in Jerusalem.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	God makes a covenant with David promising an everlasting kingdom, while David's sin brings trouble to his house.
KEY VERSE	2 Samuel 7:16
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 9; Days 262-288 (10 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

God's promise that David's throne will be established forever (7:12-16) is the center of the book. The New Testament announces Jesus as the Son of David whose kingdom has no end (Luke 1:32-33).

HOW TO READ IT

Read chapter 7 as the hinge of the book. Before it, David rises. After it, David's own sin shows that the promised king cannot be David himself.

OUTLINE

1:1-5:5	David becomes king
1:1-27	David's lament for Saul and Jonathan
2:1-4:12	Civil war between David and Saul's house
5:6-10:19	David's kingdom
5:6-25	Jerusalem and victory over the Philistines
6:1-23	The ark brought to Jerusalem
11:1-20:26	David's sin and its consequences
11:1-27	Bathsheba and Uriah
12:1-25	Nathan's rebuke and David's repentance
21:1-24:25	Appendix
21:1-22	Famine and the Philistine giants
22:1-51	David's song of deliverance

1 Kings

Glory and division

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. Jewish tradition names Jeremiah.
DATE	Covers about 970 to 850 BC. Compiled during or after the Babylonian exile.
SETTING	Solomon builds the temple, the kingdom splits, and the prophets confront kings.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	Faithfulness to the covenant brings blessing and idolatry brings decline.
KEY VERSE	1 Kings 8:23
IN THIS PLAN	Units 9 and 11; Days 289-340 (9 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Solomon builds a temple, yet even he says that heaven cannot contain God (8:27). Jesus is greater than Solomon (Matthew 12:42), he is the true temple (John 2:19-21), and Elijah's ministry prepares for John the Baptist and Jesus.

HOW TO READ IT

Notice how the narrator evaluates each king by one test: did he follow the LORD wholeheartedly as David did? Watch also how the prophets stand against power.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:46	Solomon takes the throne
1:1-53	Adonijah's attempt and Solomon anointed
2:1-46	David's charge and Solomon's consolidation
3:1-11:43	Solomon's reign
3:1-28	The request for wisdom
4:1-34	Solomon's officials and wealth
12:1-16:34	The divided kingdom
12:1-33	Rehoboam and Jeroboam
13:1-14:20	The man of God from Judah
17:1-22:53	Elijah and the house of Ahab
17:1-24	The drought, the widow, and her son
18:1-46	Mount Carmel

2 Kings

The end of the kingdoms

AUTHOR	Not named in the text.
DATE	Covers about 850 to 560 BC.
SETTING	Israel falls to Assyria in 722 BC and Judah falls to Babylon in 586 BC.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	Persistent covenant unfaithfulness ends in exile, yet a hint of hope remains for David's line.
KEY VERSE	2 Kings 17:7
IN THIS PLAN	Units 11-13; Days 341-422 (11 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Elisha's miracles, including raising a child and feeding a crowd, prepare for the greater works of Jesus. Hezekiah and Josiah show reforming kings, but neither can finally save, and the book ends with a Davidic king still alive in exile, keeping hope open.

HOW TO READ IT

This book moves quickly from king to king. Keep an eye on the prophets, who explain why events happen, and on the final chapters, where the exile is described as the covenant curse come true.

OUTLINE

1:1-8:29	Elijah and Elisha
1:1-2:25	Elijah taken up and Elisha's mantle
3:1-27	War against Moab
9:1-17:41	Jehu to the fall of Israel
9:1-10:36	Jehu's revolt
11:1-12:21	Athaliah and Joash
13:1-14:29	Kings of Israel and Judah
18:1-25:30	Judah to the exile
18:1-20:21	Hezekiah and Isaiah
21:1-26	Manasseh and Amon
22:1-23:30	Josiah's reform

1 Chronicles

Israel's story retold for the returned exiles

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. Tradition names Ezra.
DATE	Written after the exile, probably in the 400s or 300s BC.
SETTING	Written to people who had returned from exile and were rebuilding their identity.
GENRE	Genealogy and historical narrative.
THEME	God's covenant with David and the worship of the temple remain at the center of his people's hope.
KEY VERSE	1 Chronicles 17:14
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Days 522-533 (8 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The Chronicler holds the covenant with David at the center, a promise that the Messiah would come from David's line. The temple preparations point toward the final dwelling of God with his people.

HOW TO READ IT

Chronicles retells Israel's history from the viewpoint of the returned exiles. Read the opening genealogies as a statement that God's people have a name, a place, and a future.

OUTLINE

1:1-9:44	Genealogies from Adam to the exile
1:1-54	From Adam to Abraham's descendants
2:1-4:23	The tribe of Judah and the house of David
10:1-12:40	From Saul's death to David's rise
10:1-14	The death of Saul
11:1-12:40	David's mighty men and supporters
13:1-16:43	The ark brought to Jerusalem
13:1-14:17	The ark and the blessing on Obed-edom
15:1-16:43	The procession and the psalm of thanks
17:1-21:30	The Davidic covenant and wars
17:1-27	The promise of an eternal house
18:1-20:8	David's victories
22:1-29:30	Preparing for the temple
22:1-19	David's charge to Solomon
23:1-27:34	The Levites and the leaders

2 Chronicles

The kings of Judah and the temple

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. Tradition names Ezra.
DATE	Written after the exile.
SETTING	Tells the story of Solomon and the kings of Judah, ending with the exile and a call to return.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	When the king and people seek the Lord, they find him, and when they forsake him they fall.
KEY VERSE	2 Chronicles 7:14
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Days 534-547 (9 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Solomon's temple foreshadows the true temple, Christ himself. The book ends with Cyrus's decree sending the exiles home, which points ahead to the greater return from exile that the prophets promised.

HOW TO READ IT

The Chronicler emphasizes that when kings seek the LORD, they prosper, and when they forsake him, they fall. Watch the stress on repentance and revival, especially under Hezekiah and Josiah.

OUTLINE

1:1-9:31	Solomon and the temple
1:1-17	Solomon's request for wisdom
10:1-28:27	The kings of Judah
10:1-12:16	Rehoboam and the division
13:1-16:14	Abijah and Asa
29:1-32:33	Hezekiah's revival
29:1-31:21	The temple cleansed and Passover kept
32:1-33	Sennacherib's invasion
33:1-36:23	The last kings and the exile
33:1-25	Manasseh and Amon
34:1-35:27	Josiah's reform and death

Ezra

Return and rebuilding

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. Tradition names Ezra.
DATE	Covers about 538 to 458 BC.
SETTING	Jewish exiles return to Jerusalem under Persian rule and rebuild the temple.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	God keeps his promise to bring his people home, and his people must be rebuilt in obedience to the law.
KEY VERSE	Ezra 7:10
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Days 496-503 (4 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The return from exile and the rebuilding of the temple point to a greater restoration. Ezra's study and teaching of the law anticipate Christ, the final teacher of God's word.

HOW TO READ IT

Ezra covers two returns, one under Zerubbabel and one under Ezra himself. Notice the strong role of Scripture, prayer, and confession in rebuilding.

OUTLINE

1:1-6:22	The first return and the temple
1:1-11	Cyrus's decree and the return
2:1-70	The list of returning exiles
3:1-13	The altar and foundation laid
4:1-24	Opposition to the work
5:1-6:22	The temple finished and dedicated
7:1-10:44	Ezra's return and reform
7:1-28	Ezra's commission
8:1-36	The journey and the exiles who returned
9:1-15	Ezra's prayer about intermarriage
10:1-44	The people's response

Nehemiah

Rebuilding the wall

AUTHOR	Largely Nehemiah's own memoir.
DATE	Covers about 445 to 430 BC.
SETTING	Nehemiah, a cupbearer to the Persian king, returns to rebuild Jerusalem's walls.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	God's people rebuild by prayer, courage, and reading the law together.
KEY VERSE	Nehemiah 8:10
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Days 505-512 (5 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Nehemiah left a position of comfort to rebuild his people's city, and points to Christ, who left heaven to restore his people. The public reading of the law (chapter 8) points to the word of God that renews the heart.

HOW TO READ IT

Nehemiah is a leadership story. Notice how prayer and action go side by side, and how opposition grows as the work succeeds.

OUTLINE

1:1-7:73	Rebuilding the wall
1:1-11	Nehemiah's prayer
2:1-20	The king's permission and the night inspection
3:1-32	The builders listed
4:1-23	Opposition and the armed builders
5:1-19	Injustice among the people
6:1-19	The wall completed
7:1-73	The list of the people
8:1-10:39	Renewing the covenant
8:1-18	The reading of the law and the Feast of Booths
9:1-37	The prayer of confession
10:1-39	The pledge
11:1-13:31	Settling and reform
11:1-12:47	Resettlement and the dedication of the wall
13:1-31	Nehemiah's final reforms

Esther

God's hidden hand

AUTHOR	Not named in the text.
DATE	Set about 480 to 470 BC, in the reign of the Persian king Ahasuerus.
SETTING	Jews living in Persia, outside the land.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	God preserves his people through ordinary events, even when his name is not mentioned.
KEY VERSE	Esther 4:14
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Days 513-515 (3 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

God preserves his people when they cannot rescue themselves, and the line of the Messiah survives the plot to destroy it. Mordecai and Esther are courageous mediators who point to the greater mediator who gave himself for his people.

HOW TO READ IT

God is never named in Esther, yet his providence is everywhere. Look for reversals: the gallows built for Mordecai, the king's sleepless night, and the feast Haman never enjoys.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:23	Esther becomes queen
1:1-22	Vashti removed
2:1-18	Esther chosen
3:1-5:14	Haman's plot
3:1-15	The decree to destroy the Jews
4:1-17	Mordecai's plea and Esther's decision
6:1-8:17	The reversal
6:1-14	Mordecai honored
7:1-10	Esther's second banquet and Haman's fall
9:1-10:3	Purim established
9:1-19	The Jews' deliverance
9:20-32	The feast of Purim

Old Testament: Wisdom and Poetry

Job

Suffering and the wisdom of God

AUTHOR	Not named in the text.
DATE	The setting is in the patriarchal age. The date of writing is uncertain.
SETTING	A righteous man loses everything and wrestles with God and his friends.
GENRE	Wisdom poetry in a narrative frame.
THEME	Human understanding of suffering is limited, and God's wisdom and presence are enough.
KEY VERSE	Job 19:25
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 4; Days 64-86 (16 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Job longs for a mediator who could stand between him and God (9:33, 16:19-21, 19:25). Jesus is that mediator and redeemer, and he is also the righteous sufferer whose suffering was for others.

HOW TO READ IT

Job is poetry, so do not read the speeches as a debate with one right side. The friends say true things in the wrong way, and Job says bold things in pain. Notice that God never gives Job an explanation, but gives himself.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:13	The prologue
1:1-5	Job's character
3:1-31:40	Job and his friends
3:1-26	Job's lament
32:1-37:24	Elihu's speeches
32:1-33:33	Elihu begins
34:1-37:24	Elihu defends God's justice
38:1-42:6	The LORD answers
38:1-40:2	The first speech from the whirlwind
40:3-5	Job's first reply
42:7-17	The epilogue
42:7-9	The friends rebuked
42:10-17	Job restored

Psalms

The prayer book of Israel

AUTHOR	Many are attributed to David, with others to Asaph, the sons of Korah, Solomon, Moses, and unnamed authors.
DATE	Composed over many centuries, from the time of Moses to after the exile.
SETTING	Songs and prayers used in Israel's worship and personal life.
GENRE	Hebrew poetry: praise, lament, thanksgiving, wisdom, and royal psalms.
THEME	God is king, and his people can bring all their joy and sorrow to him.
KEY VERSE	Psalm 1:1-2
IN THIS PLAN	Scattered through the plan (235 days)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The psalms speak of the Messiah throughout: the anointed king (2), the suffering servant (22), the shepherd (23), the priest-king (110), and the stone the builders rejected (118). Jesus said that everything written about him in the Psalms had to be fulfilled (Luke 24:44).

HOW TO READ IT

Read one psalm at a time and ask what kind it is: praise, lament, thanksgiving, wisdom, or royal. Notice how laments usually move from complaint to trust. The psalms teach you how to pray when you do not know what to say.

OUTLINE

1-41	Book One
1-2	Introduction: the two ways and the anointed king
42-72	Book Two
42-49	Psalms of the sons of Korah
73-89	Book Three
73-83	Psalms of Asaph
90-106	Book Four
90-92	Moses, refuge, and the Sabbath song
107-150	Book Five
107	Give thanks to the LORD

Proverbs

Wisdom for daily life

AUTHOR	Largely Solomon, with sections credited to others such as Agur and Lemuel and to “the wise.”
DATE	Collected over time, from about the 900s to the 700s BC or later.
SETTING	Instruction for the young and for those who lead, drawn from experience and the fear of the Lord.
GENRE	Wisdom sayings and poems.
THEME	The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom, and wise living follows from it.
KEY VERSE	Proverbs 9:10
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 10; Days 302-320 (13 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Wisdom calls aloud in the streets (1:20-33; 8:1-36), and the New Testament says that Christ is the wisdom of God (1 Corinthians 1:24, 30; Colossians 2:3). He is the one in whom all the treasures of wisdom are hidden.

HOW TO READ IT

Proverbs are general truths, not guaranteed promises. Read them slowly, a few at a time. Notice the contrast between the wise and the foolish, the righteous and the wicked, and the repeated call to fear the LORD.

OUTLINE

1:1-9:18	A father’s appeal for wisdom
1:1-7	Purpose and motto
10:1-22:16	Proverbs of Solomon
10:1-15:33	Contrasts of the righteous and the wicked
22:17-24:34	Sayings of the wise
22:17-23:35	Thirty sayings
25:1-29:27	Hezekiah’s collection
25:1-27:27	Kings, neighbors, and fools
30:1-31:31	Final words
30:1-33	The words of Agur

Ecclesiastes

Life under the sun

AUTHOR	The speaker calls himself "the Preacher" (Qoheleth). Tradition connects the book with Solomon.
DATE	Date is uncertain, with traditional dating in the 900s BC.
SETTING	A teacher reflects on work, pleasure, wealth, and death.
GENRE	Wisdom reflection.
THEME	Life without God is empty, but life received as his gift has meaning.
KEY VERSE	Ecclesiastes 12:13
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 10; Days 321-328 (5 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Qoheleth searches for meaning under the sun and finds that nothing under the sun satisfies. The book prepares for the one who comes from above the sun, Jesus Christ, who gives meaning that does not fade.

HOW TO READ IT

The refrain "vanity" means breath or vapor. Read the book as one argument, not as a list of separate sayings. The ending tells you how to read it: fear God and keep his commandments.

OUTLINE

1:1-11	The theme
1:1-3	The Preacher and the question
1:12-2:26	The search for meaning
1:12-18	Wisdom
3:1-4:16	Time and oppression
3:1-15	A time for everything
5:1-7:29	Living wisely
5:1-7	Worship
8:1-12:8	Uncertainty and death
8:1-17	Authority and what we cannot understand
12:9-14	Conclusion
12:9-12	The words of the wise
12:13-14	Fear God and keep his commandments

Song of Songs

The beauty of married love

AUTHOR	Attributed in the title to Solomon.
DATE	Traditionally dated to the 900s BC. Date of final form is debated.
SETTING	A woman and a man exchange love poems.
GENRE	Love poetry.
THEME	God made love and marriage good, and the church has long seen in it a picture of Christ and his people.
KEY VERSE	Song of Songs 8:6-7
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 10; Days 330-331 (2 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The church has long read this book as a picture of the love between Christ and his people, though it is first of all a celebration of human love in marriage. The New Testament calls the church the bride of Christ (Ephesians 5:31-32).

HOW TO READ IT

Read the book as a collection of lyrical scenes between a woman, a man, and a chorus of friends. Do not hurry. It is poetry about desire, and it teaches a right understanding of love, in the sense of "do not awaken love until it pleases" (2:7).

OUTLINE

1:1-2:7	Longing and delight
2:8-3:5	Spring and searching
3:6-5:1	The wedding
3:6-11	The royal procession
5:2-6:3	A dream of absence
5:2-8	He knocks and is gone
6:4-8:4	Renewed praise
6:4-7:9	The lover's praise
8:5-14	Love as strong as death
8:5-7	The seal of love

Old Testament: The Major Prophets

Isaiah

Judgment, comfort, and the coming servant

AUTHOR	Isaiah son of Amoz. Some scholars see later editing, while others hold to a single author.
DATE	Isaiah's ministry ran from about 740 to 700 BC.
SETTING	Judah under threat from Assyria, and later the promise of comfort for exiles.
GENRE	Prophecy and poetry.
THEME	God judges sin and promises salvation through a coming king and suffering servant.
KEY VERSE	Isaiah 53:5
IN THIS PLAN	Units 12 and 25; Days 380-894 (22 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Isaiah speaks of a virgin's son called Immanuel (7:14), a child who is Mighty God (9:6), a branch from Jesse (11:1), a servant who bears our sins (52:13-53:12), and a herald who brings good news (61:1). The New Testament quotes the book more than any other prophet.

HOW TO READ IT

Isaiah alternates between judgment and hope. Watch for the Holy One of Israel, a title that appears throughout. The book is a unified message of sin, judgment, comfort, and a new creation.

OUTLINE

1:1-12:6	Judgment and hope for Judah
1:1-31	The LORD's case against his people
13:1-27:13	Oracles against the nations
13:1-23:18	Babylon, Moab, Egypt, Tyre, and others
28:1-39:8	Trusting God, not nations
28:1-35:10	Woes and the coming king
40:1-55:13	Comfort and the servant
40:1-31	Comfort for God's people
56:1-66:24	Restoration and new creation
56:1-59:21	Justice and repentance

Jeremiah

The weeping prophet and the new covenant

AUTHOR	Jeremiah, with Baruch as scribe.
DATE	Ministry from about 627 to 580 BC.
SETTING	The last decades of Judah and the fall of Jerusalem to Babylon.
GENRE	Prophecy, poetry, and narrative.
THEME	God judges persistent sin yet promises a new covenant written on the heart.
KEY VERSE	Jeremiah 31:33
IN THIS PLAN	Units 3 and 13; Days 32-454 (19 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Jeremiah, the weeping prophet who was rejected by his people, points to Christ, who wept over Jerusalem. The promise of a new covenant (31:31-34) is fulfilled in Jesus, who said, "This cup is the new covenant in my blood" (Luke 22:20).

HOW TO READ IT

The book is not in chronological order. Read it as a collage of sermons, poems, stories, and visions. Notice Jeremiah's personal laments, and look for the promise of a new covenant, the central hope of the book.

OUTLINE

1:1-25:38	Warnings to Judah
1:1-19	Jeremiah's call
26:1-35:19	Conflict and promise
26:1-29:32	Prophets in conflict and the letter to the exiles
30:1-33:26	The book of consolation
36:1-45:5	Jeremiah and the fall
36:1-32	The scroll burned
37:1-39:18	The siege and the fall of Jerusalem
46:1-51:64	Oracles against the nations
46:1-49:39	Egypt, Philistia, Moab, Ammon, Edom, and others
50:1-51:64	Babylon
52:1-34	The fall of Jerusalem recalled

Lamentations

Grieving Jerusalem

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. Tradition names Jeremiah.
DATE	After the fall of Jerusalem in 586 BC.
SETTING	Mourning over the destroyed city.
GENRE	Poetry in five laments.
THEME	Honest grief before God, who remains faithful even in judgment.
KEY VERSE	Lamentations 3:22-23
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 13; Days 458-460 (3 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The grieving of Jerusalem points to Jesus, the man of sorrows, who wept over the city and who bore the full weight of judgment. The hope in 3:22-23, that the LORD's mercies are new every morning, is fulfilled in him.

HOW TO READ IT

Each chapter is an acrostic poem built on the Hebrew alphabet, and the third chapter is the center of the book. Read it as a model for honest grief that does not let go of God.

OUTLINE

1:1-22	Jerusalem desolate
1:1-11	The city mourns
2:1-22	The LORD's anger
2:1-10	The LORD has destroyed
3:1-66	Hope in the LORD's mercy
3:1-20	The man who has seen affliction
4:1-22	The siege remembered
4:1-12	The city's ruin
4:13-22	Judgment on prophets and priests
5:1-22	A prayer for restoration
5:1-18	Remember what has come upon us
5:19-22	Restore us, O LORD

Ezekiel

Visions of glory and renewal

AUTHOR	Ezekiel, a priest living among the exiles.
DATE	Ministry from about 593 to 571 BC.
SETTING	The exiles in Babylon, before and after Jerusalem's fall.
GENRE	Prophecy, visions, and symbolic acts.
THEME	God's glory departs from the temple because of sin, and he promises a new heart and a restored people.
KEY VERSE	Ezekiel 36:26
IN THIS PLAN	Units 13 and 17; Days 461-638 (16 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The good shepherd of chapter 34, the new heart and spirit of chapter 36, and the river from the temple in chapter 47 all point to Christ. Jesus calls himself the good shepherd, and he gives living water.

HOW TO READ IT

Ezekiel is full of visions and symbolic acts. Watch for the repeated phrase "then they will know that I am the LORD." The book moves from the departure of God's glory to its return.

OUTLINE

1:1-3:27	Ezekiel's call
1:1-28	The vision of the glory of the LORD
4:1-24:27	Judgment on Jerusalem
4:1-7:27	Signs and oracles of judgment
25:1-32:32	Judgment on the nations
25:1-28:26	Ammon, Moab, Tyre, and Sidon
29:1-32:32	Egypt
33:1-39:29	Restoration
33:1-33	The watchman renewed
34:1-31	The shepherds and the good shepherd
40:1-48:35	The new temple
40:1-43:27	The vision of the new temple and the return of the glory
44:1-46:24	Worship and the prince

Daniel

Faithful in a foreign land

AUTHOR	Traditionally Daniel. Some scholars date the book later, so readers differ on its date.
DATE	Set in the 500s BC during the exile and Persian rule.
SETTING	Jewish exiles serve in Babylonian and Persian courts.
GENRE	Narrative and apocalyptic visions.
THEME	God rules over every empire, and his kingdom will outlast them all.
KEY VERSE	Daniel 7:13-14
IN THIS PLAN	Units 13 and 21; Days 486-775 (7 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The fourth man in the fiery furnace and the "son of man" coming on the clouds (7:13-14) point to Christ. Jesus took the title Son of Man from Daniel and is the king whose kingdom will never end.

HOW TO READ IT

Daniel has two halves: stories (1-6) and visions (7-12). The stories show faithfulness in a foreign court. The visions show God ruling over history. Note that the book is written partly in Hebrew and partly in Aramaic.

OUTLINE

1:1-21	Daniel and his friends in Babylon
2:1-49	Nebuchadnezzar's dream
3:1-30	The fiery furnace
3:1-18	The golden image and the refusal
4:1-37	Nebuchadnezzar humbled
4:1-27	The dream of the tree
5:1-31	The writing on the wall
6:1-28	Daniel in the lions' den
7:1-28	Four beasts and the Son of Man
7:1-14	The vision
8:1-12:13	Visions of the future
8:1-27	The ram and the goat

Old Testament: The Minor Prophets

Hosea

A faithful God and an unfaithful people

AUTHOR	Hosea.
DATE	Ministry in the northern kingdom, about 750 to 722 BC.
SETTING	Israel falls into idolatry. Hosea's marriage becomes a picture of God's love.
GENRE	Prophecy.
THEME	God loves his people even when they are unfaithful and calls them back.
KEY VERSE	Hosea 6:6
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 11; Days 363-367 (4 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

God's patient love for an unfaithful bride, shown in Hosea's marriage, points to Christ and his church. Matthew 2:15 applies "out of Egypt I called my son" to Jesus, and Paul quotes Hosea about Gentiles becoming "my people" (Romans 9:25).

HOW TO READ IT

Hosea is a book of painful love. Watch for the shifts between accusation and tenderness. The names of Hosea's children are messages, and they are later reversed.

OUTLINE

1:1-3:5	Hosea's marriage
1:1-2:1	Gomer and the three children
2:2-23	The unfaithful wife and the restored bride
3:1-5	Hosea buys Gomer back
4:1-14:9	God's case against Israel
4:1-6:3	No knowledge of God
6:4-11:11	Israel's unfaithfulness and God's compassion
11:1-11	The father's love
12:1-14:9	A call to return

Joel

The day of the Lord

AUTHOR	Joel.
DATE	Date is debated, with proposals from the 800s to the 400s BC.
SETTING	A locust plague becomes a picture of coming judgment.
GENRE	Prophecy.
THEME	Return to the Lord, and he will pour out his Spirit.
KEY VERSE	Joel 2:28
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Days 548-549 (2 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Joel promises that the Spirit will be poured out on all flesh (2:28-32). Peter says this was fulfilled at Pentecost (Acts 2:16-21). The day of the LORD finds its center in Christ.

HOW TO READ IT

Joel uses a plague of locusts as a picture of a greater judgment. Read it as a call to repent, with the promise that God will restore and pour out his Spirit.

OUTLINE

1:1-20	The locust plague
1:1-12	The land devastated
1:13-20	A call to lament
2:1-17	The day of the LORD
2:1-11	An army of judgment
2:12-17	Return to me with all your heart
2:18-27	The LORD's answer
2:18-27	Restoration of the land
2:28-3:21	The Spirit and the final judgment
2:28-32	The Spirit poured out
3:1-16	The nations judged
3:17-21	The LORD dwells in Zion

Amos

Justice rolling like water

AUTHOR	Amos, a herdsman from Tekoa.
DATE	About 760 to 750 BC.
SETTING	Prosperous Israel ignores the poor and worships falsely.
GENRE	Prophecy.
THEME	God demands justice and true worship, and promises to restore David's house.
KEY VERSE	Amos 5:24
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 11; Days 354-356 (3 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Amos looks forward to restoring David's fallen tent (9:11-12), which James quotes at the council in Jerusalem to explain the Gentiles' inclusion (Acts 15:15-18). Christ is the one who fulfills justice.

HOW TO READ IT

Amos is a shepherd from Judah speaking to the north. Notice how he begins with judgment on the neighbors and then turns to Israel itself. The book ends in hope.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:16	Judgment on the nations and Israel
1:1-2	The LORD roars
1:3-2:5	Syria, Philistia, Tyre, Edom, Ammon, Moab, and Judah
2:6-16	Israel
3:1-6:14	Sermons against Israel
3:1-15	Chosen and accountable
4:1-13	Failure to return
5:1-27	A lament and a call to seek the LORD
6:1-14	Woe to those at ease
7:1-9:10	Visions of judgment
7:1-9	Locusts, fire, and the plumb line
7:10-17	Amos and Amaziah
8:1-14	The basket of summer fruit
9:1-10	The LORD beside the altar
9:11-15	Restoration
9:11-15	David's tent rebuilt

Obadiah

Judgment on Edom

AUTHOR	Obadiah.
DATE	Probably after the fall of Jerusalem in 586 BC, though debated.
SETTING	Edom gloated over Judah's fall.
GENRE	Prophecy, the shortest book of the Old Testament.
THEME	Pride falls, and the Lord's kingdom will come.
KEY VERSE	Obadiah 1:15
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Day 550

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The final verse, "the kingdom shall be the LORD's," points forward to the kingdom of Christ. Edom's pride is set against the humility of the Messiah.

HOW TO READ IT

Obadiah is one chapter and is best read in one sitting. Notice the theme of reversal: Edom's pride is brought down, and Israel's lowly remnant is lifted up.

OUTLINE

1-4	The announcement
1	The vision and the call to war
2-4	Edom brought down
5-9	The completeness of the judgment
5-7	Looters and betrayal
8-9	The wise and mighty destroyed
10-14	The reason for judgment
10-11	Violence and standing aside
12-14	Do not gloat
15-18	The day of the LORD
15-16	As you did, it shall be done to you
17-18	Zion and the house of Jacob
19-21	The kingdom shall be the LORD's
19-20	The land possessed
21	Saviors on Mount Zion

Jonah

A reluctant prophet and a merciful God

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. The prophet Jonah appears in 2 Kings 14.
DATE	Set in the 700s BC.
SETTING	Jonah is sent to Nineveh, the capital of Assyria.
GENRE	Narrative.
THEME	God's mercy reaches even Israel's enemies.
KEY VERSE	Jonah 4:2
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 11; Days 370-372 (2 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Jesus called Jonah's three days in the fish a sign of his own death and resurrection (Matthew 12:39-41). He said that one greater than Jonah is here.

HOW TO READ IT

Jonah is a story with a surprise ending. Notice that the question at the end is addressed to Jonah, and the book leaves it open for the reader to answer.

OUTLINE

1:1-17	Jonah flees
1:1-3	The call and the flight
1:4-16	The storm and the sailors
1:17	The great fish
2:1-10	Jonah's prayer
2:1-9	Prayer from the fish
2:10	Jonah delivered
3:1-10	Nineveh repents
3:1-4	The second call
3:5-10	The city turns and God relents
4:1-11	Jonah's anger and God's question
4:1-5	Jonah complains
4:6-11	The plant and the question

Micah

Justice, mercy, and a ruler from Bethlehem

AUTHOR	Micah.
DATE	About 735 to 700 BC.
SETTING	Judah and Israel under Assyrian threat.
GENRE	Prophecy.
THEME	God judges injustice and promises a shepherd king from Bethlehem.
KEY VERSE	Micah 6:8
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 11; Days 373-375 (3 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Micah 5:2 names Bethlehem as the birthplace of the ruler whose origin is from of old, and the chief priests quoted it to Herod (Matthew 2:5-6). The shepherd king is Jesus.

HOW TO READ IT

Micah has three cycles, each beginning with "Hear" and each moving from judgment to hope. Notice the famous summary in 6:8.

OUTLINE

1:1-3:12	First cycle: judgment
1:1-16	The LORD comes down
2:1-13	Greed and the remnant
3:1-12	Rulers and prophets rebuked
4:1-5:15	Second cycle: hope
4:1-8	The mountain of the LORD
4:9-5:1	Exile and rescue
5:2-15	The ruler from Bethlehem
6:1-7:20	Third cycle: God's case and pardon
6:1-8	What does the LORD require
6:9-7:6	Judgment and lament
7:7-20	Who is a God like you

Nahum

The fall of Nineveh

AUTHOR	Nahum.
DATE	Probably between about 663 and 612 BC.
SETTING	Nineveh, the Assyrian capital, will fall.
GENRE	Prophecy and poetry.
THEME	God is slow to anger but will judge oppression.
KEY VERSE	Nahum 1:7
IN THIS PLAN	Units 12 and 20; Days 417-726 (2 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Nahum 1:15 speaks of the messenger who brings good news and announces peace, which is quoted by Paul about the gospel (Romans 10:15). The justice of God against oppression is satisfied fully in Christ.

HOW TO READ IT

Nahum is a poem about the end of an empire. Read it as the other side of Jonah: Nineveh repented once, but later returned to cruelty.

OUTLINE

1:1-15	The LORD's power
1:1-8	The LORD is a jealous and avenging God
1:9-15	The end of the plot and good news for Judah
2:1-13	The fall described
2:1-10	The attack on the city
2:11-13	The lion's den
3:1-19	Why Nineveh falls
3:1-7	Woe to the bloody city
3:8-19	No escape

Habakkuk

Questions and faith

AUTHOR	Habakkuk.
DATE	Probably about 610 to 600 BC.
SETTING	Habakkuk asks why God allows injustice in Judah and then why he uses Babylon.
GENRE	Prophecy, dialogue, and prayer.
THEME	The righteous live by faith, trusting God even when circumstances are hard.
KEY VERSE	Habakkuk 2:4
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 12; Day 418

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Habakkuk 2:4, "the righteous shall live by his faith," is quoted three times in the New Testament (Romans 1:17; Galatians 3:11; Hebrews 10:38). The just live by faith in Christ.

HOW TO READ IT

Habakkuk is a conversation between the prophet and God. Follow the sequence: complaint, answer, complaint, answer, and then a prayer of trust.

OUTLINE

1:1-11	First complaint and answer
1:1-4	How long, O LORD
1:5-11	I am doing a work: Babylon
1:12-2:20	Second complaint and answer
1:12-2:1	Why are you silent
2:2-5	The righteous live by faith
2:6-20	Five woes
3:1-19	Habakkuk's prayer
3:1-15	The LORD comes in glory
3:16-19	Though the fig tree should not blossom

Zephaniah

The day of the Lord and a restored remnant

AUTHOR	Zephaniah.
DATE	Probably about 640 to 620 BC, in the reign of Josiah.
SETTING	Judah faces judgment, with a call to seek the Lord.
GENRE	Prophecy.
THEME	God judges the proud and gathers the humble, rejoicing over them.
KEY VERSE	Zephaniah 3:17
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 12; Day 419

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The promise that the LORD will rejoice over his people with singing (3:17) is realized in Christ, who gathers the scattered and rejoices over them.

HOW TO READ IT

Zephaniah begins with total judgment and ends with joyful singing. Notice how "the day of the LORD" is dark for the proud and bright for the humble.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:3	Judgment and a call to seek the LORD
1:1-6	Judgment on the whole earth
1:7-18	The day of the LORD
2:1-3	Seek the LORD
2:4-15	Judgment on the nations
2:4-7	Philistia
2:8-15	Moab, Ammon, Cush, and Assyria
3:1-20	Jerusalem and restoration
3:1-8	The rebellious city
3:9-13	A purified remnant
3:14-20	Sing, O daughter of Zion

Haggai

Rebuild the house

AUTHOR	Haggai.
DATE	About 520 BC.
SETTING	Returned exiles have neglected the temple.
GENRE	Prophecy.
THEME	Put God first, and he will be with his people.
KEY VERSE	Haggai 2:9
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Day 555

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The promise that the glory of the latter house will be greater than the former (2:9) is fulfilled when Christ comes to the temple. Zerubbabel, a descendant of David, is a sign of the coming king.

HOW TO READ IT

Haggai has four short messages, each dated precisely. Watch how God moves the people from self-concern to obedience and from discouragement to hope.

OUTLINE

1:1-15	The first message: rebuild the temple
1:1-11	Consider your ways
1:12-15	The people obey
2:1-9	The second message: the coming glory
2:1-5	Take courage
2:6-9	The latter glory
2:10-19	The third message: blessing
2:10-19	From this day I will bless you
2:20-23	The fourth message: Zerubbabel
2:20-23	The LORD's signet ring

Zechariah

Visions of hope for the returned exiles

AUTHOR	Zechariah. Some scholars see a different author for the later chapters.
DATE	Begins about 520 BC.
SETTING	Returned exiles are encouraged to finish the temple.
GENRE	Prophecy and visions.
THEME	God will cleanse his people and send a humble king.
KEY VERSE	Zechariah 9:9
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Days 556-561 (5 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Zechariah 9:9, the king who comes humble and riding on a donkey, is fulfilled at the triumphal entry. The pierced one (12:10), the shepherd who is struck (13:7), and the fountain for sin (13:1) all point to Christ.

HOW TO READ IT

Zechariah is full of visions and symbols. Read the visions in chapters 1 to 6 as encouragement for builders, and chapters 9 to 14 as oracles about the coming king.

OUTLINE

1:1-6	A call to return
1:1-6	Return to me
1:7-6:15	Eight night visions
1:7-17	The horsemen
1:18-2:13	The horns and the measuring line
3:1-10	Joshua the high priest cleansed
7:1-8:23	Questions about fasting
7:1-14	True fasting
8:1-23	Jerusalem restored
9:1-14:21	Oracles of the coming king
9:1-17	The humble king
10:1-11:17	The shepherds
12:1-13:9	The pierced one and the cleansing fountain

Malachi

The last word of the Old Testament

AUTHOR	Malachi.
DATE	Probably about 450 to 400 BC.
SETTING	The returned community has grown lax in worship and covenant faithfulness.
GENRE	Prophecy in a dialogue style.
THEME	God loves his people and calls them to faithful worship, with a messenger promised before the day of the Lord.
KEY VERSE	Malachi 3:1
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Days 562-563 (2 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Malachi promises a messenger who will prepare the way (3:1) and the sun of righteousness who rises with healing (4:2). The New Testament identifies John the Baptist as the messenger and Jesus as the LORD who comes to his temple.

HOW TO READ IT

Malachi is a series of questions and answers. God makes a claim, the people ask "How?" and God replies. Read it as a covenant lawsuit in dialogue form.

OUTLINE

1:1-5	God's love for Israel
1:1-5	I have loved you
1:6-2:9	Corrupt priests
1:6-14	Blemished offerings
2:1-9	A warning to the priests
2:10-16	Faithlessness
2:10-16	Breaking the covenant in marriage
2:17-3:5	The coming messenger
2:17-3:5	Where is the God of justice
3:6-4:6	Return to me
3:6-12	Robbing God
3:13-4:3	The book of remembrance and the day
4:4-6	Remember the law and Elijah

New Testament: Gospels and Acts

Matthew

Jesus, the promised king

AUTHOR	Traditionally the apostle Matthew. The book itself is anonymous.
DATE	Often dated between about AD 60 and 85.
SETTING	Written with a strong Jewish background, showing Jesus as the fulfillment of the Old Testament.
GENRE	Gospel: a narrative of Jesus' life with five major teaching sections.
THEME	Jesus is the Messiah and king who brings the kingdom of heaven.
KEY VERSE	Matthew 16:16
IN THIS PLAN	Units 5, 15, 21, 22 and 25; Days 111-892 (29 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Matthew presents Jesus as the promised Messiah, the son of David and son of Abraham, who fulfills the Law and the Prophets. He is Immanuel, "God with us" (1:23), and he ends with the promise, "I am with you always" (28:20).

HOW TO READ IT

Matthew gathers Jesus' teaching into five great discourses, each ending with a phrase such as "when Jesus had finished these sayings." Watch for the phrase "this was to fulfill what was spoken by the prophet."

OUTLINE

1:1-4:11	Birth and preparation
4:12-7:29	The kingdom proclaimed
8:1-10:42	The kingdom in power
11:1-13:52	Responses to the kingdom
11:1-12:50	Rejection and growing opposition
13:53-18:35	The church and the cross approaching
13:53-16:12	Withdrawal and feeding the multitudes
19:1-25:46	Jerusalem
19:1-20:34	Journey to Jerusalem
26:1-28:20	Passion and resurrection
26:1-27:66	Last supper, trial, and crucifixion

Mark

Jesus, the suffering servant

AUTHOR	Traditionally John Mark, associated with Peter. The book itself is anonymous.
DATE	Often dated between about AD 55 and 70.
SETTING	Written in a brisk style, likely for a wider audience, including Gentile readers.
GENRE	Gospel.
THEME	Jesus is the Son of God who came to serve and give his life as a ransom.
KEY VERSE	Mark 10:45
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 18; Days 666-685 (14 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Mark moves quickly to show Jesus as the Son of God who came to serve and to give his life as a ransom for many (10:45). The centurion at the cross is the first human to confess him as the Son of God (15:39).

HOW TO READ IT

Mark is the shortest Gospel and the most action-driven. Watch for the word "immediately." Notice how often Jesus tells people not to tell, and how the disciples struggle to understand.

OUTLINE

1:1-13	The beginning
1:1-8	John the Baptist
1:14-8:26	Ministry in Galilee
1:14-3:12	Authority and early opposition
8:27-10:52	The way of the cross
8:27-9:29	Peter's confession and the transfiguration
9:30-10:52	Teaching on discipleship
11:1-13:37	Jerusalem
11:1-12:44	Entry, temple, and controversies
13:1-37	The Olivet discourse
14:1-16:8	Passion and resurrection
14:1-72	The Last Supper, Gethsemane, and trial
15:1-47	The crucifixion and burial

Luke

Jesus, savior for all people

AUTHOR	Traditionally Luke, a physician and companion of Paul. The book itself is anonymous.
DATE	Often dated between about AD 60 and 85.
SETTING	Addressed to Theophilus, and first volume of a two-part work with Acts.
GENRE	Gospel, with careful historical narrative.
THEME	Jesus came to seek and to save the lost, including the poor and outsiders.
KEY VERSE	Luke 19:10
IN THIS PLAN	Units 15, 16, 18 and 21; Days 571-779 (21 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Luke shows Jesus as the Savior of the world who seeks and saves the lost (19:10). Only Luke includes the parables of the good Samaritan, the lost son, and the rich man and Lazarus, and he ends on the road to Emmaus, where Jesus explains the Scriptures about himself.

HOW TO READ IT

Luke is the first of two volumes, with Acts. Watch for his interest in the poor, women, outsiders, prayer, and the Holy Spirit. Notice the long travel section from 9:51.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:52	Birth and childhood
3:1-4:13	Preparation
3:1-38	John, baptism, and genealogy
4:14-9:50	Ministry in Galilee
4:14-5:39	Nazareth and the first disciples
9:51-19:27	Journey to Jerusalem
9:51-13:21	Teaching and mission
19:28-23:56	Final week and cross
19:28-21:38	Entry and teaching
24:1-53	Resurrection and ascension
24:1-35	The empty tomb and the Emmaus road

John

Jesus, the Word made flesh

AUTHOR	Traditionally the apostle John. The book itself does not name its author.
DATE	Often dated between about AD 80 and 95.
SETTING	Selected signs and teachings written so that readers believe.
GENRE	Gospel, with a different structure from Matthew, Mark, and Luke.
THEME	Jesus is the eternal Son of God, and eternal life comes through believing in him.
KEY VERSE	John 20:31
IN THIS PLAN	Units 17, 19, 21 and 24; Days 634-860 (22 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

John begins with the Word who is God and became flesh, and ends so that readers may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God. Seven "I am" sayings and seven signs show who he is.

HOW TO READ IT

John is built around signs, long discourses, and the "hour" of the cross. Read it slowly. Notice repeated words like "believe," "life," "light," "truth," and "abide."

OUTLINE

1:1-18	The prologue
1:1-5	The Word was God
1:6-18	The Word became flesh
1:19-12:50	The book of signs
1:19-2:12	The first disciples and water into wine
2:13-4:54	Temple, Nicodemus, and the woman at the well
13:1-17:26	The farewell
13:1-38	Footwashing and the new commandment
14:1-16:33	The way, the Spirit, and the vine
18:1-20:31	Passion and resurrection
18:1-19:42	Arrest, trial, and crucifixion
20:1-31	The empty tomb and Thomas
21:1-25	Epilogue
21:1-25	Breakfast by the sea and Peter restored

Acts

The church begins and spreads

AUTHOR	Traditionally Luke, the author of the third Gospel.
DATE	Covers about AD 30 to 62. Often dated to the 60s or later.
SETTING	The early church spreads from Jerusalem to Rome.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	The risen Christ builds his church through the Holy Spirit, taking the gospel to all nations.
KEY VERSE	Acts 1:8
IN THIS PLAN	Units 15, 19, 22 and 23; Days 600-830 (26 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Acts continues what Jesus began to do and teach (1:1), now through the Spirit and the church. Luke shows the risen Christ ruling from heaven, adding to his church, and bringing the gospel to every nation.

HOW TO READ IT

Acts follows the plan of 1:8: Jerusalem, Judea and Samaria, and the ends of the earth. Watch for summary statements such as "the word of God continued to increase" that mark each stage.

OUTLINE

1:1-8:3	Witness in Jerusalem
1:1-26	The ascension and the replacement of Judas
8:4-12:25	Judea, Samaria, and the first Gentiles
8:4-40	Philip in Samaria and the Ethiopian
13:1-15:35	The first journey and the Jerusalem council
13:1-14:28	Paul and Barnabas sent out
15:1-35	The Jerusalem council
15:36-21:16	Paul's later journeys
15:36-18:22	Macedonia, Athens, and Corinth
18:23-20:38	Ephesus and the farewell
21:17-28:31	Arrest and Rome
21:17-23:35	Arrest in Jerusalem
24:1-26:32	Before Felix, Festus, and Agrippa

New Testament: Paul's Letters

Romans

The gospel explained

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 57.
SETTING	Written to believers in Rome, a church Paul had not yet visited.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	Righteousness from God comes by faith in Christ to Jew and Gentile alike.
KEY VERSE	Romans 1:16-17
IN THIS PLAN	Units 1, 4, 5, 12, 15, 19, 20, 21, 22 and 24; Days 6-860 (28 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Romans shows that God's righteousness is revealed in Christ, who was delivered up for our trespasses and raised for our justification (4:25). Christ is the second Adam (5:12-21), the end of the law for righteousness (10:4), and the one in whom there is no condemnation (8:1).

HOW TO READ IT

Romans is a tightly argued letter. Read it in large sections. Chapters 1 to 8 explain the gospel, 9 to 11 explain God's plan for Israel, and 12 to 16 explain how to live it.

OUTLINE

1:1-17	Introduction
1:18-3:20	All are guilty
3:21-5:21	Justification by faith
3:21-31	Righteousness through faith in Christ
6:1-8:39	New life in Christ
6:1-23	Dead to sin, alive to God
9:1-11:36	God's plan for Israel
9:1-29	God's sovereign choice
12:1-15:13	Living the gospel
12:1-21	Living sacrifices
15:14-16:27	Paul's plans and greetings
15:14-33	Paul's ministry

1 Corinthians

Order and love in a divided church

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 53 to 55.
SETTING	Written to the church in Corinth, which faced division and moral problems.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	The cross reshapes church life, and love is the way of Christ's people.
KEY VERSE	1 Corinthians 15:3-4
IN THIS PLAN	Units 18, 21 and 22; Days 667-801 (14 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul says that Christ crucified is the power and wisdom of God (1:23-24), that Christ is our Passover lamb (5:7), and that he has been raised as the firstfruits of those who have died (15:20).

HOW TO READ IT

1 Corinthians answers specific questions and problems in a divided church. Notice how Paul returns to the cross in each section, and how chapter 13 on love sits in the middle of the discussion of gifts.

OUTLINE

1:1-4:21	Division and the cross
1:1-17	Greeting and appeal for unity
5:1-7:40	Moral questions
5:1-6:20	Immorality and lawsuits
8:1-11:1	Food offered to idols
8:1-13	Knowledge and love
11:2-14:40	Worship and gifts
11:2-34	Order in worship and the Lord's Supper
12:1-31	Spiritual gifts and one body
15:1-58	The resurrection
15:1-11	The gospel of first importance
15:12-34	If Christ is not raised
16:1-24	The collection and closing

2 Corinthians

Weakness and ministry

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 55 to 56.
SETTING	Paul defends his ministry and urges generosity and reconciliation.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	God's power appears in weakness, and the new covenant ministry gives new life.
KEY VERSE	2 Corinthians 12:9
IN THIS PLAN	Units 4, 15, 19, 21 and 25; Days 87-892 (9 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul says that the one who knew no sin became sin for us (5:21), that Christ's grace was sufficient in weakness (12:9), and that God has shone in our hearts to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Christ (4:6).

HOW TO READ IT

2 Corinthians is Paul's most personal letter. Notice how he defends his ministry not by showing strength, but by showing weakness, and how he ties his suffering to the cross.

OUTLINE

1:1-7:16	Paul's ministry
1:1-2:17	Comfort and the change of plans
3:1-4:6	The new covenant ministry
4:7-5:21	Treasure in jars of clay and reconciliation
6:1-7:16	Open hearts and godly grief
8:1-9:15	The collection for Jerusalem
8:1-24	The example of the Macedonians
9:1-15	God loves a cheerful giver
10:1-13:14	Paul defends his apostleship
10:1-18	Paul's authority
11:1-12:10	The fool's speech and the thorn in the flesh
12:11-13:14	Final warnings and greetings

Galatians

Freedom in the gospel

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Dated between about AD 48 and 55, depending on where the churches were located.
SETTING	Paul writes to churches being pressured to add the law to the gospel.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	We are justified by faith in Christ, not by works of the law.
KEY VERSE	Galatians 2:20
IN THIS PLAN	Units 20-21; Days 730-757 (6 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul says that Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us (3:13), and that he now lives in believers (2:20). The central message is that Christ alone is enough.

HOW TO READ IT

Galatians is a letter of urgency. Paul does not begin with thanksgiving. Notice the movement from the defense of the gospel to its meaning to its fruit in daily life.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:21	Paul defends the gospel
1:1-10	No other gospel
1:11-2:10	Paul's call and the Jerusalem leaders
2:11-21	Paul opposes Peter and justification by faith
3:1-4:31	Faith and the law
3:1-14	Abraham and the blessing
3:15-29	The purpose of the law
4:1-31	Sons and heirs
5:1-6:18	Freedom and the Spirit
5:1-15	Stand firm in freedom
5:16-26	The fruit of the Spirit
6:1-18	Bear one another's burdens

Ephesians

The church in Christ

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul. Some scholars question this, though the church has long affirmed Pauline authorship.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 60 to 62, from prison.
SETTING	Written to believers in Ephesus and perhaps nearby churches.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	God has united Jew and Gentile in Christ, and calls the church to live worthy of that calling.
KEY VERSE	Ephesians 2:8-9
IN THIS PLAN	Units 4, 20, 21 and 22; Days 86-790 (9 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul says that all things are summed up in Christ (1:10), that Christ is the cornerstone of the household of God (2:20), and that the church is his body and his bride (5:25-32).

HOW TO READ IT

Ephesians has two halves: what God has done (chapters 1 to 3) and how we then live (chapters 4 to 6). Watch for the repeated phrase “in Christ” and for the long sentences, especially in chapter 1.

OUTLINE

1:1-3:21	What God has done in Christ
1:1-14	Every spiritual blessing
1:15-23	Prayer for understanding
2:1-10	Saved by grace through faith
2:11-22	One new man
3:1-21	The mystery and the prayer
4:1-6:24	How the church lives
4:1-16	Unity and gifts
4:17-5:21	The old self and the new
5:22-6:9	Households
6:10-20	The armor of God
6:21-24	Closing

Philippians

Joy in Christ

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 60 to 62, from prison.
SETTING	Written to a loved and generous church in Philippi.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	Christ is our joy, our example, and our goal.
KEY VERSE	Philippians 4:13
IN THIS PLAN	Units 17, 20, 21 and 22; Days 635-796 (6 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The hymn in 2:6-11 is one of the clearest statements of Christ's humility, incarnation, death, and exaltation. Paul says that to live is Christ and to die is gain (1:21).

HOW TO READ IT

Philippians is a letter of joy written from prison. Count how many times "joy" and "rejoice" appear. Notice how Paul ties humility and unity to the example of Christ.

OUTLINE

1:1-26	Paul's situation
1:1-11	Greeting, thanks, and prayer
1:12-26	Chains and the advance of the gospel
1:27-2:18	Unity and humility
1:27-2:4	Live worthy of the gospel
2:5-11	The mind of Christ
2:12-18	Work out your salvation
2:19-3:21	Examples and warnings
2:19-30	Timothy and Epaphroditus
3:1-11	Paul's former gain, now loss
3:12-21	Pressing on toward the goal
4:1-23	Encouragements and thanks
4:1-9	Rejoice and think on these things
4:10-23	Thanks for the gift

Colossians

Christ is supreme

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 60 to 62, from prison.
SETTING	Written to a church facing false teaching.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	Christ is sufficient and supreme over all things.
KEY VERSE	Colossians 1:15-17
IN THIS PLAN	Units 15, 17 and 22; Days 600-801 (6 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Colossians 1:15-20 describes Christ as the image of the invisible God, the creator and sustainer of all things, and the one who reconciles all things through the blood of his cross.

HOW TO READ IT

Colossians answers a false teaching with a large picture of Christ. Notice the argument: because Christ is supreme and sufficient, you were raised with him, so live that way.

OUTLINE

1:1-14	Greeting and prayer
1:1-8	Thanksgiving
1:9-14	Prayer for knowledge
1:15-2:23	The supremacy of Christ
1:15-23	Christ preeminent
1:24-2:5	Paul's labor
2:6-23	Warnings against empty philosophy
3:1-4:6	New life in Christ
3:1-17	Put off the old and put on the new
3:18-4:1	Households
4:2-6	Prayer and wise conduct
4:7-18	Final greetings

1 Thessalonians

Hope in Christ's return

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 50 to 51.
SETTING	Written to a young church facing persecution.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	Stay faithful and hopeful, for Christ will return.
KEY VERSE	1 Thessalonians 4:16-17
IN THIS PLAN	Units 20 and 22; Days 740-804 (4 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul writes about the coming of the Lord Jesus, when he descends from heaven, the dead in Christ rise, and we are with the Lord forever (4:16-17). Christ is the one who delivers us from the wrath to come (1:10).

HOW TO READ IT

Notice that each chapter ends with the coming of Christ. Paul writes to encourage a church that is suffering and worried about loved ones who have died.

OUTLINE

1:1-3:13	Thanksgiving and Paul's care
1:1-10	The faith of the Thessalonians
2:1-16	Paul's ministry among them
2:17-3:13	Longing to see them
4:1-5:28	Living for the Lord
4:1-12	Holiness and love
4:13-18	The coming of the Lord
5:1-11	The day of the Lord
5:12-28	Final instructions

2 Thessalonians

Standing firm until the Day

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 50 to 52.
SETTING	Written to correct confusion about the day of the Lord.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	Stand firm and keep working while waiting for Christ.
KEY VERSE	2 Thessalonians 2:15
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 22; Day 809

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Christ will be revealed from heaven with his mighty angels (1:7), and the Lord Jesus will destroy the man of lawlessness by the breath of his mouth (2:8).

HOW TO READ IT

This letter corrects a misunderstanding about the day of the Lord. Notice how Paul balances confidence in Christ's return with the call to steady work.

OUTLINE

1:1-12	Encouragement in persecution
1:1-4	Thanks for their faith
1:5-12	Justice at the revelation of Christ
2:1-17	The day of the Lord
2:1-12	The man of lawlessness
2:13-17	Stand firm
3:1-18	Prayer, work, and closing
3:1-5	Pray for us
3:6-15	Warning against idleness
3:16-18	Benediction

1 Timothy

Order in the church

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul. Some scholars question Pauline authorship of the pastoral letters, though the church has long affirmed it.
DATE	Usually dated in the early 60s AD.
SETTING	Written to Timothy, who is leading the church in Ephesus.
GENRE	Pastoral letter.
THEME	Guard sound teaching and organize the church for godly life.
KEY VERSE	1 Timothy 3:15
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 22; Days 810-813 (3 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul says that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners (1:15), that there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus (2:5), and that the church is the pillar and buttress of the truth (3:15).

HOW TO READ IT

1 Timothy is a letter from an older pastor to a younger pastor. Notice how Paul returns to sound teaching, godly character, and the dangers of false teaching and love of money.

OUTLINE

1:1-20	Warning against false teachers
1:1-11	The law and false teaching
1:12-20	Paul's testimony and charge
2:1-3:16	Worship and leadership
2:1-15	Prayer and conduct in worship
3:1-13	Overseers and deacons
3:14-16	The mystery of godliness
4:1-6:21	Instructions for Timothy and the church
4:1-16	A good servant of Christ Jesus
5:1-6:2	Widows, elders, and slaves
6:3-21	Contentment, wealth, and a final charge

2 Timothy

Paul's last letter

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 64 to 67.
SETTING	Paul writes from prison, expecting to die.
GENRE	Pastoral letter.
THEME	Be faithful, guard the gospel, and pass it on.
KEY VERSE	2 Timothy 3:16-17
IN THIS PLAN	Units 1 and 22; Days 2-815 (3 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul says that Christ Jesus abolished death and brought life and immortality to light through the gospel (1:10), and that the Lord stood by him and strengthened him (4:17).

HOW TO READ IT

2 Timothy is Paul's last letter, written near the end of his life. Notice the urgency: guard the gospel, endure suffering, and pass it on.

OUTLINE

1:1-18	Do not be ashamed
1:1-7	Fan into flame the gift of God
1:8-18	Do not be ashamed of the testimony
2:1-26	Be strong and endure
2:1-13	A soldier, athlete, and farmer
2:14-26	A worker approved
3:1-17	Hold to Scripture
3:1-9	Difficult times
3:10-17	All Scripture is breathed out by God
4:1-22	Preach the word
4:1-8	I have fought the good fight
4:9-22	Personal requests and final words

Titus

Good works that adorn the gospel

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated in the early to mid-60s AD.
SETTING	Written to Titus on the island of Crete.
GENRE	Pastoral letter.
THEME	The grace of God leads to godly living.
KEY VERSE	Titus 2:11-12
IN THIS PLAN	Units 17 and 22; Days 638-816 (3 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul says that Christ Jesus gave himself for us to redeem us from all lawlessness and to purify for himself a people for his own possession (2:14). Our hope is the appearing of our great God and Savior, Jesus Christ.

HOW TO READ IT

Titus is a short letter about how sound doctrine leads to good works. Notice the repeated call to "good works" and to a life that adorns the gospel.

OUTLINE

1:1-16	Appointing elders
1:1-4	Greeting
1:5-9	Qualifications for elders
1:10-16	Rebuking false teachers
2:1-15	Teaching for every group
2:1-10	Older men and women, younger men, and slaves
2:11-15	The grace of God has appeared
3:1-15	Doing good
3:1-8	Saved not by works but by mercy
3:9-15	Final instructions

Philemon

A plea for a runaway slave

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 60 to 62.
SETTING	Paul writes to Philemon about Onesimus.
GENRE	Personal letter.
THEME	The gospel changes relationships, making masters and slaves brothers.
KEY VERSE	Philemon 15-16
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 22; Day 817

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul appeals for Onesimus on the basis of love, as one who stands in Christ's place for a debtor, "charge that to my account" (v. 18). The letter pictures what Christ has done for us.

HOW TO READ IT

Philemon is a personal letter and a model of persuasion. Notice how Paul appeals instead of commanding, and how he reframes Onesimus as a brother.

OUTLINE

1-3	Greeting
1-2	The senders and recipients
3	Grace and peace
4-7	Thanksgiving and prayer
4-5	Philemon's faith and love
6-7	Prayer for the sharing of faith
8-16	The appeal for Onesimus
8-11	Appeal for my child
12-16	No longer as a slave but as a beloved brother
17-22	The request
17-19	Charge it to my account
20-22	Refresh my heart and prepare a guest room
23-25	Closing greetings

New Testament: General Letters and Revelation

Hebrews

Christ is better

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. The author is unknown, and several names have been suggested.
DATE	Usually dated before AD 70, though not certain.
SETTING	Written to believers tempted to turn back.
GENRE	Sermon in the form of a letter.
THEME	Jesus is greater than angels, Moses, and the priests, and his sacrifice is final.
KEY VERSE	Hebrews 4:14
IN THIS PLAN	Units 3, 7, 12, 17, 19, 22, 23 and 24; Days 32-839 (17 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Hebrews presents Jesus as superior to the prophets, angels, Moses, and the Levitical priesthood. He is the great high priest and the once-for-all sacrifice who sat down at the right hand of God.

HOW TO READ IT

Hebrews alternates between exposition and warning. Notice the repeated word "better" and the five warning passages. The letter is written as a word of exhortation to endure.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:18	Jesus is greater than angels
1:1-4	God has spoken by his Son
3:1-4:13	Jesus is greater than Moses
3:1-6	Faithful as a Son
4:14-7:28	Jesus is the greater priest
4:14-5:10	A sympathetic high priest
8:1-10:18	The new covenant and sacrifice
8:1-13	A better covenant
10:19-12:29	Faith and endurance
10:19-39	Draw near and hold fast
11:1-40	The hall of faith
13:1-25	Final instructions
13:1-19	Love and obedience
13:20-25	Benediction

James

Faith that works

AUTHOR	James. Tradition identifies him as the brother of Jesus.
DATE	Often dated in the 40s or 60s AD.
SETTING	Written to Jewish Christians scattered abroad.
GENRE	Letter with wisdom teaching.
THEME	Genuine faith produces practical obedience.
KEY VERSE	James 2:17
IN THIS PLAN	Units 1 and 24; Days 4-842 (6 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

James calls himself a servant of the Lord Jesus Christ and speaks of the coming of the Lord (5:7-8). The wisdom he describes, pure, peaceable, and gentle, is the character of Christ.

HOW TO READ IT

James is like a sermon in short sections. Notice the many echoes of Jesus' Sermon on the Mount, and that he is not opposing faith, but showing how genuine faith acts.

OUTLINE

1:1-18	Trials and temptations
1:1-12	Joy in trials
1:13-18	God does not tempt
1:19-2:26	Hearing and doing
1:19-27	Be doers of the word
2:1-13	No partiality
2:14-26	Faith and works
3:1-4:12	Words and wisdom
3:1-12	Taming the tongue
3:13-4:12	Wisdom from above and worldliness
4:13-5:20	Patience and prayer
4:13-5:6	Boasting and the rich
5:7-20	Patience, oaths, and the prayer of faith

1 Peter

Hope in suffering

AUTHOR	The apostle Peter.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 62 to 65.
SETTING	Written to scattered believers facing hostility.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	Christians live as exiles with a living hope.
KEY VERSE	1 Peter 1:3
IN THIS PLAN	Units 4, 12, 22 and 24; Days 87-849 (6 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Peter says that Christ suffered for us, leaving us an example (2:21), bore our sins in his body on the tree (2:24), and that we are redeemed with the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish (1:18-19).

HOW TO READ IT

1 Peter is addressed to suffering Christians. Notice how he links suffering and glory, and how he calls the church "exiles" and "a holy priesthood."

OUTLINE

1:1-2:10	A living hope and a holy people
1:1-12	Born again to a living hope
1:13-2:3	Be holy
2:4-10	A chosen race and a royal priesthood
2:11-3:12	Living honorably
2:11-25	Submission and the example of Christ
3:1-12	Wives, husbands, and all
3:13-5:14	Suffering and humility
3:13-22	Suffering for righteousness
4:1-19	Living for God
5:1-14	Elders, humility, and greetings

2 Peter

Remember and grow

AUTHOR	The apostle Peter. Some scholars question this, while the church has long affirmed it.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 64 to 68.
SETTING	Written to warn against false teachers.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	Grow in knowledge of Christ and hold fast until he returns.
KEY VERSE	2 Peter 3:9
IN THIS PLAN	Units 1, 24 and 25; Days 2-894 (5 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Peter speaks of the power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ (1:16), the transfiguration as an eyewitness testimony, and the promise of new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells (3:13).

HOW TO READ IT

2 Peter is Peter's farewell. Notice his concern that readers remember what they have been taught and not be carried away by false teachers.

OUTLINE

1:1-21	Growing in godliness
1:1-11	Make your calling and election sure
1:12-21	The reliability of the apostolic testimony
2:1-22	False teachers
2:1-10	Their judgment is certain
2:11-22	Their character exposed
3:1-18	The day of the Lord
3:1-13	Scoffers and the patience of the Lord
3:14-18	Grow in grace

1 John

Assurance of eternal life

AUTHOR	Traditionally the apostle John.
DATE	Often dated about AD 85 to 95.
SETTING	Written to believers troubled by false teaching.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	Walk in the light, love one another, and know that you have eternal life.
KEY VERSE	1 John 5:13
IN THIS PLAN	Units 21 and 24; Days 754-860 (5 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

John begins with the word of life that we have heard, seen, and touched (1:1-4), says that Jesus Christ the righteous is our advocate (2:1), and says that God sent his Son to be the propitiation for our sins (4:10).

HOW TO READ IT

1 John circles back to three themes: light and sin, righteousness and obedience, and love. Notice the tests of genuine faith: believing in Jesus, obeying his commands, and loving the brothers.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:2	Walking in the light
1:1-4	The word of life
1:5-2:2	Light, sin, and the advocate
2:3-27	Obedience and love
2:3-11	Keeping his commandments
2:12-17	Do not love the world
2:18-27	Antichrists
2:28-4:6	Children of God
2:28-3:10	Righteousness and sin
3:11-24	Love one another
4:1-6	Test the spirits
4:7-5:12	Love and faith
4:7-21	God is love
5:1-12	Faith overcomes the world
5:13-21	Assurance
5:13-21	That you may know that you have eternal life

2 John

Truth and love

AUTHOR	The author calls himself "the elder," and tradition identifies him with John.
DATE	Often dated about AD 85 to 95.
SETTING	Written to "the elect lady and her children."
GENRE	Short letter.
THEME	Walk in truth and love, and avoid false teachers.
KEY VERSE	2 John 6
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 24; Day 862

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

John warns against those who do not confess that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh (v. 7). The true teaching about Christ is the center of the letter.

HOW TO READ IT

2 John is one page. Notice how it holds together truth and love, and how it warns against welcoming teachers who deny Christ.

OUTLINE

1-3	Greeting
1-2	The elder to the elect lady
3	Grace, mercy, and peace
4-6	Walk in love
4	Walking in the truth
5-6	Love one another
7-11	Beware of deceivers
7	Many deceivers
8-11	Do not receive them
12-13	Closing

3 John

Hospitality for the truth

AUTHOR	The author calls himself "the elder."
DATE	Often dated about AD 85 to 95.
SETTING	Written to Gaius about hospitality for traveling teachers.
GENRE	Short letter.
THEME	Support those who work for the truth.
KEY VERSE	3 John 8
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 24; Day 863

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

John says that the traveling teachers went out for the sake of the name (v. 7). Christ's name is the reason for hospitality and the center of the mission.

HOW TO READ IT

3 John is the most personal of John's letters. Notice the three people: Gaius, Diotrephes, and Demetrius, and the contrast between hospitality and pride.

OUTLINE

1-4	Greeting to Gaius
1-2	The elder to the beloved Gaius
3-4	Walking in the truth
5-8	Support the missionaries
5-6	Faithful in all you do
7-8	Fellow workers for the truth
9-12	Diotrephes and Demetrius
9-10	Diotrephes who loves to be first
11-12	Imitate good, and Demetrius is commended
13-15	Closing

Jude

Contend for the faith

AUTHOR	Jude, who calls himself a brother of James.
DATE	Often dated in the 60s AD.
SETTING	Written to warn against false teachers.
GENRE	Short letter.
THEME	Defend the faith once delivered and keep yourselves in God's love.
KEY VERSE	Jude 24-25
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 24; Day 864

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Jude calls Jesus Christ our only Master and Lord (v. 4) and ends by pointing to the one who is able to keep us from stumbling and present us blameless with great joy (v. 24).

HOW TO READ IT

Jude is a short, urgent letter. Notice the many examples from Scripture and Jewish tradition, and the call to build yourself up and keep yourself in the love of God.

OUTLINE

1-2	Greeting
1-2	Jude, servant of Jesus Christ
3-4	The reason for writing
3	Contend for the faith
4	Ungodly people have crept in
5-16	The danger of false teachers
5-7	Examples from the past
8-13	Their character
14-16	The prophecy of Enoch
17-23	How to persevere
17-19	Remember the apostles' warning
20-23	Build yourselves up and show mercy
24-25	Doxology

Revelation

The unveiling of Jesus Christ

AUTHOR	John, traditionally the apostle John.
DATE	Often dated about AD 95, though some propose the 60s.
SETTING	Written to seven churches in Asia Minor facing pressure.
GENRE	Apocalyptic prophecy and letter.
THEME	Christ wins, evil is judged, and God makes all things new.
KEY VERSE	Revelation 21:5
IN THIS PLAN	Units 22 and 25; Days 803-895 (17 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Revelation is the unveiling of Jesus Christ (1:1). He is the first and the last, the lamb who was slain and is worthy, the faithful and true rider, and the bridegroom who returns for his bride.

HOW TO READ IT

Revelation is full of symbols, and most of them come from the Old Testament. Read for the big picture: Christ reigns, the church is called to faithful witness, evil is judged, and God makes all things new.

OUTLINE

1:1-20	Vision of Christ
1:1-8	Prologue and greeting
2:1-3:22	Letters to seven churches
2:1-3:6	Ephesus to Sardis
4:1-5:14	The throne and the Lamb
4:1-11	The throne in heaven
6:1-16:21	Seals, trumpets, and bowls
6:1-8:5	The seven seals
17:1-20:15	Babylon and the final judgment
17:1-19:5	The fall of Babylon
21:1-22:21	The new heaven and new earth
21:1-8	The new Jerusalem
21:9-22:5	The city described